

How Many People Follow a Member of Congress

Three platforms, one question, and three different Congresses

Democracy's Data

Last updated 31 August 2026

A member of Congress's follower count gets quoted like an election result. A representative with two million followers is described as a force. A senator with twenty thousand is described as quiet. The number is standing in for political weight, and it is worth asking whether it has earned the job.

Congress makes that checkable, because its hierarchy is a matter of public record. Which chamber a member sits in, how long they have been there, and what they chair are all published. Every member also has an audience anybody can count. Set the two beside each other and see whether they agree.

Counting the audience turns out to be the hard half. Nobody publishes the number.

01 The test

The counts here were read off the screen, one profile at a time, on 2026-08-15. Every one of the 537 sitting members of Congress was looked for on 3 platforms: X, Instagram and Bluesky. That comes to 1,611 looks at a profile, misses included, and the reading is frozen at that date so the numbers in this text stay checkable.

Why read profile pages, when so much else about Congress arrives as a file? There is no file. The House does not keep one and neither does the Senate. The platforms know each number exactly and either sell access to it or do not sell it at all. X prices the count behind an interface starting at \$200 a month (<https://developer.x.com/en/products/x-api>), and Instagram offers no equivalent a reader could use. Bluesky answers a public request with an exact count and asks for no account and no key (<https://public.api.bsky.app>).

So the number is taken the way any member of the public gets it. You open the profile signed out, and you write down what is on the screen.

A follower count is a platform's own ledger, kept while the platform was doing something else. Nobody was measuring a politician's standing when the row was written. A server was recording that an account had clicked a button, and the description of a politician is a by-product. The section introduction is about that whole family of records, and about what changes when a file describes people nobody set out to describe.

02 The data

Deciding who counts as Congress comes first, and it is a decision a reader may argue with. The roster used here is `unitedstates/congress-legislators` (<https://unitedstates.github.io/congress-legislators/>), a list of sitting members kept by volunteers rather than by either chamber. Its Congress is 537 people rather than 535, because it includes the 6 delegates who sit and speak and vote in committee but not on the floor. Neither figure is wrong. What is wrong is not saying which one you used.

Then the handles. You cannot ask a platform for the account belonging to the senator from Massachusetts. You can only ask about a handle, and no official body publishes the list. The same volunteer project keeps a crosswalk, a table that translates one list into another, here from a member to their accounts on X and Instagram. Bluesky is not in it at all, so those handles were guessed: take the member's name and put it under their own chamber's own domain, as in `schiff.senate.gov`.

That guess has a property worth pausing on. A handle ending in `senate.gov` can only exist if somebody who controls `senate.gov` put it there, because the platform checks the claim against the domain's own records. A hit cannot be an impersonator. Search Bluesky by name instead and the top results for a well-known member include accounts whose own descriptions say *Parody* and *Satirical*.

Two cleaning decisions shape everything below. **Misses are recorded rather than dropped, and recorded by kind.** No handle known means the roster lists no account for that member. No account found means the member appears not to be on the platform. A third kind means the roster names a handle the platform does not have, which is a different failure from either.

The counts are kept in the form the platform gives them. X prints 11.5M rather than a number, and no amount of tidying turns the first into the second.

`all_members.csv` therefore carries `state`, `chamber`, `member` and `party`, then one column per platform: `x`, `instagram` and `bluesky`, each holding either a count or the named reason there is none. `coverage.csv` carries `platform`, `members`, `handle_on_file`, `count_read`, the three miss columns and `pct_covered`. `party_coverage.csv` splits that coverage by party, and `platform_leaders.csv` names the most-followed member each platform knows about.

Before you read on, commit to a number. Instagram is the one platform here that returns whole numbers rather than rounded ones, and it gave a count for 388 members. Add all of those counts together, then take the ten largest accounts. **What share of the whole do those ten members hold?** Write a percentage down now, before you turn the page.

03 What it says about democracy

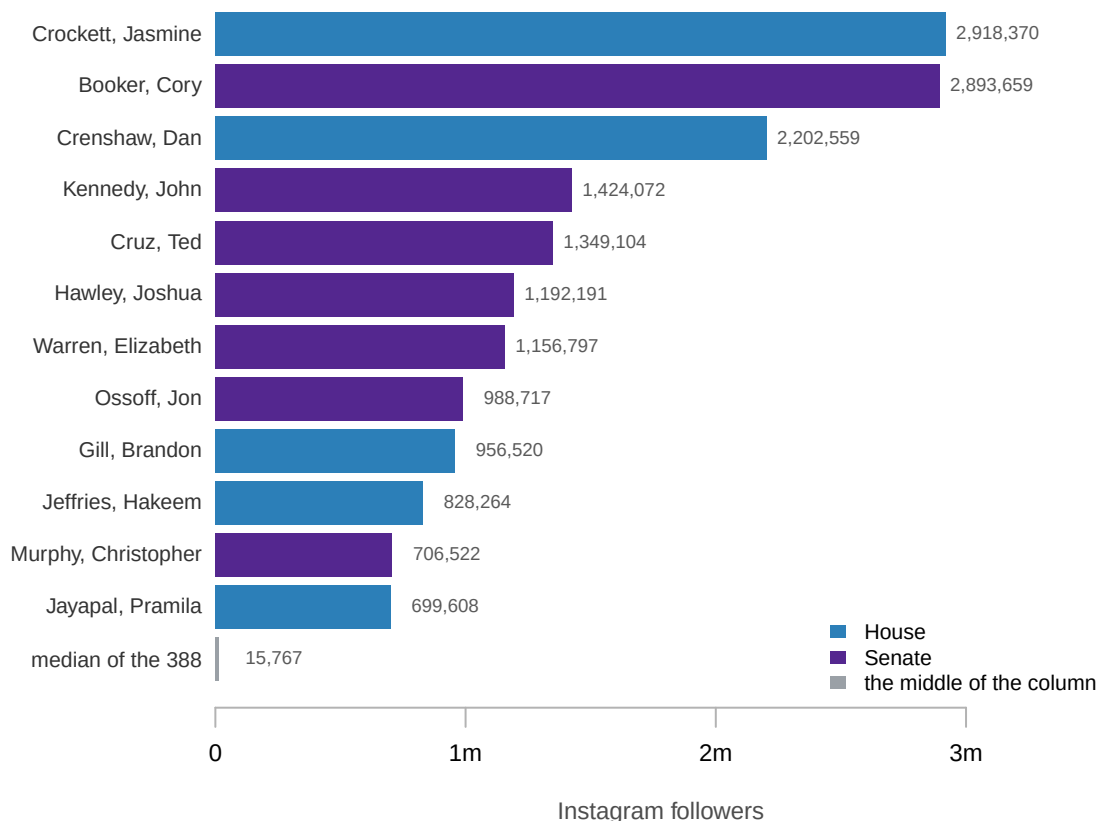


Figure 1. The twelve largest congressional accounts on Instagram, and the middle of the same column. A ranked bar chart fits this question because the question is about shape: how far the top of a distribution stands above the ordinary case. The bottom bar is the median of the 388 members whose count was read, drawn on the same axis as the rest, and colour is the chamber the member sits in.

The ten largest accounts hold 43.3% of all the followers in that column. The bottom half of the same list holds 3.6%. The largest single account belongs to Crockett, Jasmine, with 185 times as many followers as the median member. Measured the way economists measure income, the distribution scores 0.81 on a scale where 0 would mean every member had the same audience and 1 that one member had all of it.

Now set that shape against the institution. Office is not irrelevant. Senators are 19.3% of the members counted and 12 of the twenty-five largest accounts, and the median senator here has 50,751 followers against 10,550 for the median representative. The more powerful chamber does have the larger audiences.

The audience is still distributed far more unequally than the offices are. Nobody in Congress holds 185 times another member's vote, and the largest account of all belongs to a member of the House, as do 5 of the twelve in the figure. Seniority does not appear in that list, and neither does leadership.

The two most senior figures in the file are not in the file at all. Mike Johnson, the Speaker of the House, and John Thune, the Senate majority leader, both appear with handles on file that neither platform has, which is the third kind of miss. Their audiences may well be enormous. What is certain is that the roster is not tracking them, and nothing about their

offices made it more likely to.

So the answer to the opening question is a qualified no. A follower count tracks the chamber a member sits in, loosely. It does not track anything finer, and the scale it works on belongs to fame rather than to office.

That last point is a fact about the file as much as about Congress, and it generalises.

Each platform describes a different Congress.

Platform	Members	Handle on file	Count read	No handle known	No account found	Handle wrong	% of Congress
X	537	505	490	32	0	15	91.2
Instagram	537	407	388	130	0	19	72.3
Bluesky	537	135	135	0	402	0	25.1

Not one of them covers the whole institution. The best of them, X, gave a number for 490 of 537 members. 34 handles across the platforms are on file and wrong, and those are not scattered at random.

Member	Party	Now sits in	Handle the roster still lists
Elissa Slotkin	Democrat	Senate	RepSlotkin
Jacky Rosen	Democrat	Senate	repjackyrosen
Jim Banks	Republican	Senate	RepJimBanks
Jim Banks	Republican	Senate	repjimbanks
John Curtis	Republican	Senate	RepJohnCurtis
John Curtis	Republican	Senate	repjohncurtis

11 of them belong to a member who was promoted. They moved from the House to the Senate, renamed the account to match the new job, and the roster went on pointing at the old name. A hand-maintained list decays fastest around the people whose careers move fastest, which leaves it least reliable about the members most likely to be studied.

The sorting can be far larger than that.

Party	Members of Congress	Found on Bluesky	%
Democrat	260	134	51.5
Independent	3	1	33.3
Republican	274	0	0.0

134 Democrats have a verified Bluesky account under their own chamber's domain, 51.5% of the party. Republicans have 0, out of 274. This is not a flaw in the collection and not a quirk of the guessing rule, which builds the same candidate handles from a Republican's name as from a Democrat's. The rule found no Republicans because there are almost none to find.

Party	Members of Congress	Found on X	%
Republican	274	246	89.8
Democrat	260	241	92.7
Independent	3	3	100.0

X covers Republicans at 89.8% and Democrats at 92.7%. The chamber did not change between these two tables. **The instrument did.** A sentence like *the median member of Congress has N followers* is therefore a different sentence on each platform, and on Bluesky it is a claim about Democrats wearing the word Congress.

Platform	Most followed member	Party	Followers	Members covered
Bluesky	Bernard Sanders	Independent	572,693	135
Instagram	Jasmine Crockett	Democrat	2,918,370	388
X	Bernard Sanders	Independent	11.5M	490

The platforms cannot even agree on who is first. Between them they name 2 different people as the most-followed member of Congress, and each is correct about its own slice. The last column is the reason: no two of them hold the same part of the institution.

Every member, every platform

Congress is small enough to print whole, so here it is: all 537 members, sorted by state with senators first. Find your own delegation and check it against the profiles.

Where there is no number, the reason is named rather than left blank, because a blank reads as zero and none of these are zero. **no handle** means no account is listed for that member on that platform. **handle wrong** means an account is listed and the platform does not have it. A dash means nothing answered under the member's own chamber domain.

State	Chamber	Member	Party	X	Instagram	Bluesky
AK	Senate	Murkowski, Lisa	R	337.4K	33,425	—
AK	Senate	Sullivan, Dan	R	76K	18,950	—
AK	House	Begich, Nicholas	R	10.1K	1,315	—
AL	Senate	Britt, Katie	R	133.2K	108,404	—
AL	Senate	Tuberville, Tommy	R	166.7K	38,229	—
AL	House	Aderholt, Robert	R	40.2K	no handle	—
AL	House	Figures, Shomari	D	1,766	6,808	—
AL	House	Moore, Barry	R	25.9K	no handle	—
AL	House	Palmer, Gary	R	30.6K	4,842	—
AL	House	Rogers, Mike	R	55.1K	5,879	—
AL	House	Sewell, Terri	D	53.6K	43,867	1,993
AL	House	Strong, Dale	R	9,941	5,277	—

State	Chamber	Member	Party	X	Instagram	Bluesky
AR	Senate	Boozman, John	R	116.3K	17,298	—
AR	Senate	Cotton, Tom	R	821.9K	no handle	—
AR	House	Crawford, Eric	R	34.2K	3,817	—
AR	House	Hill, J.	R	38.6K	9,250	—
AR	House	Westerman, Bruce	R	17.9K	no handle	—
AR	House	Womack, Steve	R	34.8K	9,502	—
AS	House	Radewagen, Aumua Amata	R	4,706	no handle	—
AZ	Senate	Gallego, Ruben	D	handle wrong	handle wrong	32,993
AZ	Senate	Kelly, Mark	D	286.4K	553,777	—
AZ	House	Ansari, Yassamin	D	67.3K	188,266	—
AZ	House	Biggs, Andy	R	1.1M	24,562	—
AZ	House	Ciscomani, Juan	R	12.7K	4,902	—
AZ	House	Crane, Eli	R	162.8K	no handle	—
AZ	House	Gosar, Paul	R	386.8K	18,414	—
AZ	House	Grijalva, Adelita	D	no handle	no handle	—
AZ	House	Hamadeh, Abraham	R	no handle	no handle	—
AZ	House	Schweikert, David	R	39.9K	8,914	—
AZ	House	Stanton, Greg	D	23.4K	13,135	—
CA	Senate	Padilla, Alejandro	D	117.2K	228,614	83,374
CA	Senate	Schiff, Adam	D	3.3M	611,892	234,655
CA	House	Aguilar, Pete	D	45.3K	no handle	22,136
CA	House	Barragán, Nanette	D	30.2K	13,640	—
CA	House	Bera, Ami	D	47.6K	8,440	16,286
CA	House	Brownley, Julia	D	21K	4,828	37,106
CA	House	Calvert, Ken	R	28.5K	4,792	—
CA	House	Carbajal, Salud	D	19K	17,398	21,927
CA	House	Chu, Judy	D	77.5K	21,087	14,020
CA	House	Cisneros, Gilbert	D	no handle	8,068	5,706
CA	House	Correa, J.	D	23.4K	28,187	—
CA	House	Costa, Jim	D	29.6K	no handle	—
CA	House	DeSaulnier, Mark	D	22.5K	5,701	—
CA	House	Fong, Vince	R	3,190	3,363	—
CA	House	Friedman, Laura	D	2,362	9,207	3,066
CA	House	Gallagher, James	R	no handle	no handle	—
CA	House	Garamendi, John	D	34.6K	26,131	—
CA	House	Garcia, Robert	D	77K	133,522	12,483
CA	House	Gomez, Jimmy	D	59.5K	192,600	24,305
CA	House	Gray, Adam	D	1,239	1,844	—
CA	House	Harder, Josh	D	20.4K	no handle	—

State	Chamber	Member	Party	X	Instagram	Bluesky
CA	House	Huffman, Jared	D	50.2K	74,576	—
CA	House	Issa, Darrell	R	240.5K	no handle	—
CA	House	Jacobs, Sara	D	68.4K	223,440	53,502
CA	House	Kamlager-Dove, Sydney	D	17.6K	143,920	36,470
CA	House	Khanna, Ro	D	175.4K	187,624	35,500
CA	House	Kiley, Kevin	I	36.7K	no handle	—
CA	House	Kim, Young	R	59.7K	29,730	—
CA	House	Levin, Mike	D	38K	55,236	37,453
CA	House	Liccardo, Sam	D	3,154	5,614	4,228
CA	House	Lieu, Ted	D	183.5K	535,201	—
CA	House	Lofgren, Zoe	D	89.2K	no handle	2,358
CA	House	Matsui, Doris	D	41.5K	6,479	—
CA	House	McClintock, Tom	R	32.4K	19,702	—
CA	House	Min, Dave	D	no handle	no handle	—
CA	House	Mullin, Kevin	D	6,872	8,902	22,295
CA	House	Oberholte, Jay	R	11.4K	no handle	—
CA	House	Panetta, Jimmy	D	24K	25,273	—
CA	House	Pelosi, Nancy	D	8.1M	no handle	17,638
CA	House	Peters, Scott	D	30K	8,188	—
CA	House	Rivas, Luz	D	2,048	25,542	—
CA	House	Ruiz, Raul	D	29.7K	no handle	—
CA	House	Sánchez, Linda	D	46K	13,541	—
CA	House	Sherman, Brad	D	149.9K	57,814	—
CA	House	Simon, Lateefah	D	3,009	106,904	—
CA	House	Takano, Mark	D	52.8K	26,617	—
CA	House	Thompson, Mike	D	43.2K	no handle	4,951
CA	House	Torres, Norma	D	80.8K	33,403	—
CA	House	Tran, Derek	D	no handle	no handle	—
CA	House	Valadao, David	R	24.8K	no handle	—
CA	House	Vargas, Juan	D	27K	8,778	11,885
CA	House	Waters, Maxine	D	1.4M	483,404	—
CA	House	Whitesides, George	D	1,533	8,053	—
CO	Senate	Bennet, Michael	D	276.1K	handle wrong	37,921
CO	Senate	Hickenlooper, John	D	45.5K	22,521	2,940
CO	House	Boebert, Lauren	R	1.4M	no handle	—
CO	House	Crank, Jeff	R	4,180	1,847	—
CO	House	Crow, Jason	D	176.9K	no handle	42,501
CO	House	DeGette, Diana	D	63.2K	no handle	18,447
CO	House	Evans, Gabe	R	10.7K	2,343	—

State	Chamber	Member	Party	X	Instagram	Bluesky
CO	House	Hurd, Jeff	R	3,812	2,925	—
CO	House	Neguse, Joe	D	206K	no handle	31,779
CO	House	Pettersen, Brittany	D	28.5K	33,608	8,045
CT	Senate	Blumenthal, Richard	D	654.6K	149,516	24,489
CT	Senate	Murphy, Christopher	D	4,045	706,522	—
CT	House	Courtney, Joe	D	27.6K	8,318	—
CT	House	DeLauro, Rosa	D	64.1K	no handle	39,171
CT	House	Hayes, Jahana	D	41.3K	53,434	—
CT	House	Himes, James	D	99.4K	76,516	—
CT	House	Larson, John	D	41.3K	55,474	—
DC	House	Norton, Eleanor	D	63.7K	15,990	—
DE	Senate	Blunt Rochester, Lisa	D	35.9K	38,769	14,052
DE	Senate	Coons, Christopher	D	214.2K	53,464	9,029
DE	House	McBride, Sarah	D	no handle	142,826	30,560
FL	Senate	Moody, Ashley	R	no handle	no handle	—
FL	Senate	Scott, Rick	R	739.9K	156,098	—
FL	House	Bean, Aaron	R	8,882	2,956	—
FL	House	Bilirakis, Gus	R	40.6K	5,032	—
FL	House	Buchanan, Vern	R	36.3K	7,743	—
FL	House	Cammack, Katherine	R	127.4K	56,395	—
FL	House	Castor, Kathy	D	27.5K	15,555	—
FL	House	Diaz-Balart, Mario	R	112.3K	71,672	—
FL	House	Donalds, Byron	R	538.5K	545,134	—
FL	House	Dunn, Neal	R	18.8K	no handle	—
FL	House	Fine, Randall	R	no handle	no handle	—
FL	House	Frankel, Lois	D	31.9K	9,584	30,451
FL	House	Franklin, C.	R	14K	23,694	—
FL	House	Frost, Maxwell	D	68.3K	179,351	24,628
FL	House	Gimenez, Carlos	R	175.4K	106,796	—
FL	House	Haridopolos, Mike	R	6,205	no handle	—
FL	House	Lee, Laurel	R	14.2K	14,451	—
FL	House	Luna, Anna	R	620.8K	359,967	—
FL	House	Mast, Brian	R	149.6K	94,110	—
FL	House	Mills, Cory	R	59.9K	45,184	—
FL	House	Moskowitz, Jared	D	66.1K	155,511	—
FL	House	Patronis, Jimmy	R	no handle	no handle	—
FL	House	Rutherford, John	R	21.6K	6,692	—
FL	House	Salazar, Maria	R	212.6K	560,800	—
FL	House	Soto, Darren	D	25.4K	16,580	—

State	Chamber	Member	Party	X	Instagram	Bluesky
FL	House	Steube, W.	R	134.9K	27,891	—
FL	House	Wasserman Schultz, Debbie	D	26K	handle wrong	23,693
FL	House	Webster, Daniel	R	32.1K	no handle	—
FL	House	Wilson, Frederica	D	67.6K	20,938	—
GA	Senate	Ossoff, Jon	D	70K	988,717	33,799
GA	Senate	Warnock, Raphael	D	183.7K	no handle	32,380
GA	House	Allen, Rick	R	29.7K	5,435	—
GA	House	Bishop, Sanford	D	25.5K	no handle	3,479
GA	House	Carter, Earl	R	47.4K	8,846	—
GA	House	Clyde, Andrew	R	52.1K	10,434	—
GA	House	Collins, Mike	R	132.3K	5,568	—
GA	House	Fuller, Clay	R	no handle	no handle	—
GA	House	Jack, Brian	R	9,424	2,082	—
GA	House	Johnson, Henry	D	53.4K	21,205	—
GA	House	Loudermilk, Barry	R	56.3K	6,674	—
GA	House	McBath, Lucy	D	49.5K	27,221	8,836
GA	House	McCormick, Rich	R	59.9K	33,481	—
GA	House	Scott, Austin	R	35.3K	no handle	—
GA	House	Williams, Nikema	D	24K	28,090	—
GU	House	Moylan, James (Jim)	R	handle wrong	3,806	—
HI	Senate	Hirono, Mazie	D	449.3K	40,630	15,519
HI	Senate	Schatz, Brian	D	57.3K	95,657	—
HI	House	Case, Ed	D	11.3K	5,485	—
HI	House	Tokuda, Jill	D	4,724	15,113	16,374
IA	Senate	Ernst, Joni	R	255.3K	33,275	—
IA	Senate	Grassley, Charles	R	1M	97,292	—
IA	House	Feenstra, Randy	R	20.8K	no handle	—
IA	House	Hinson, Ashley	R	60.6K	no handle	—
IA	House	Miller-Meeks, Mariannette	R	29.1K	no handle	—
IA	House	Nunn, Zachary (Zach)	R	9,445	3,914	—
ID	Senate	Crapo, Michael	R	139.4K	11,850	—
ID	Senate	Risch, James	R	135.3K	no handle	—
ID	House	Fulcher, Russ	R	20.9K	3,547	—
ID	House	Simpson, Michael	R	29.9K	5,864	—
IL	Senate	Duckworth, Tammy	D	656.3K	336,256	72,046
IL	Senate	Durbin, Richard	D	683.9K	no handle	17,946
IL	House	Bost, Mike	R	25.5K	no handle	—
IL	House	Budzinski, Nicole (Nikki)	D	6,329	4,317	22,178
IL	House	Casten, Sean	D	39.2K	15,434	45,914

State	Chamber	Member	Party	X	Instagram	Bluesky
IL	House	Davis, Danny	D	19.5K	no handle	—
IL	House	Foster, Bill	D	49.9K	no handle	—
IL	House	García, Jesús	D	43.7K	no handle	—
IL	House	Jackson, Jonathan	D	no handle	7,106	25,227
IL	House	Kelly, Robin	D	38.9K	23,091	20,225
IL	House	Krishnamoorthi, Raja	D	157.9K	41,403	—
IL	House	LaHood, Darin	R	27.3K	no handle	—
IL	House	Miller, Mary	R	210.6K	no handle	—
IL	House	Quigley, Mike	D	51.4K	10,483	34,941
IL	House	Ramirez, Delia	D	30.8K	186,995	12,997
IL	House	Schakowsky, Janice	D	51K	11,681	4,831
IL	House	Schneider, Bradley	D	23K	12,053	—
IL	House	Sorensen, Eric	D	6,953	4,338	—
IL	House	Underwood, Lauren	D	122.1K	no handle	33,539
IN	Senate	Banks, Jim	R	handle wrong	handle wrong	—
IN	Senate	Young, Todd	R	99.3K	14,996	—
IN	House	Baird, James	R	14.2K	no handle	—
IN	House	Carson, André	D	62.1K	29,216	21,971
IN	House	Houchin, Erin	R	8,564	2,789	—
IN	House	Messmer, Mark	R	no handle	10	—
IN	House	Mrvan, Frank	D	6,439	no handle	—
IN	House	Shreve, Jefferson	R	1,694	1,270	—
IN	House	Spartz, Victoria	R	93.6K	no handle	—
IN	House	Stutzman, Marlin	R	15.7K	2,127	—
IN	House	Yakym, Rudy	R	12.3K	no handle	—
KS	Senate	Marshall, Roger	R	1,730	13,607	—
KS	Senate	Moran, Jerry	R	124K	89	—
KS	House	Davids, Sharice	D	61.4K	no handle	13,106
KS	House	Estes, Ron	R	13.9K	3,668	—
KS	House	Mann, Tracey	R	7,554	4,488	—
KS	House	Schmidt, Derek	R	1,641	1,062	—
KY	Senate	McConnell, Mitch	R	91.1K	13,811	—
KY	Senate	Paul, Rand	R	364K	509,750	—
KY	House	Barr, Garland	R	39.4K	7,936	—
KY	House	Comer, James	R	281.5K	25,541	—
KY	House	Guthrie, Brett	R	26.9K	4,926	—
KY	House	Massie, Thomas	R	1.7M	559,832	—
KY	House	McGarvey, Morgan	D	12.9K	28,457	—
KY	House	Rogers, Harold	R	24K	6,761	—

State	Chamber	Member	Party	X	Instagram	Bluesky
LA	Senate	Cassidy, Bill	R	107.9K	10,386	—
LA	Senate	Kennedy, John	R	1.7M	1,424,072	—
LA	House	Carter, Troy	D	9,439	no handle	—
LA	House	Fields, Cleo	D	1,078	6,374	—
LA	House	Higgins, Clay	R	232.2K	37,219	—
LA	House	Johnson, Mike	R	handle wrong	handle wrong	—
LA	House	Letlow, Julia	R	14.3K	no handle	—
LA	House	Scalise, Steve	R	703.8K	89,557	—
MA	Senate	Markey, Edward	D	276.2K	39,371	89,331
MA	Senate	Warren, Elizabeth	D	6.7M	1,156,797	415,319
MA	House	Auchincloss, Jake	D	39.8K	no handle	—
MA	House	Clark, Katherine	D	handle wrong	130,779	—
MA	House	Keating, William	D	26.8K	no handle	27,434
MA	House	Lynch, Stephen	D	30.1K	10,110	19,272
MA	House	McGovern, James	D	163.8K	87,143	—
MA	House	Moulton, Seth	D	19.6K	42,746	34,443
MA	House	Neal, Richard	D	39.1K	no handle	6,331
MA	House	Pressley, Ayanna	D	497.2K	412,273	103,535
MA	House	Trahan, Lori	D	39.5K	29,995	13,649
MD	Senate	Alsobrooks, Angela	D	no handle	56,341	24,260
MD	Senate	Van Hollen, Chris	D	289.1K	303,325	129,029
MD	House	Elfreth, Sarah	D	2,817	10,704	6,765
MD	House	Harris, Andy	R	41.4K	no handle	—
MD	House	Hoyer, Steny	D	144.1K	handle wrong	3,211
MD	House	Ivey, Glenn	D	5,956	13,121	10,925
MD	House	McClain Delaney, April	D	2,964	3,168	—
MD	House	Mfume, Kweisi	D	7,163	10,751	—
MD	House	Olszewski, Johnny	D	2,899	7,983	—
MD	House	Raskin, Jamie	D	943.9K	232,012	265,940
ME	Senate	Collins, Susan	R	523.2K	25,549	—
ME	Senate	King, Angus	I	225K	no handle	—
ME	House	Golden, Jared	D	25.2K	no handle	13,327
ME	House	Pingree, Chellie	D	33.8K	39,085	41,599
MI	Senate	Peters, Gary	D	148.1K	23,864	11,070
MI	Senate	Slotkin, Elissa	D	handle wrong	380,346	37,258
MI	House	Barrett, Tom	R	7,126	no handle	—
MI	House	Bergman, Jack	R	32K	6,852	—
MI	House	Dingell, Debbie	D	92.9K	17,932	44,954
MI	House	Huizenga, Bill	R	38.1K	7,653	—

State	Chamber	Member	Party	X	Instagram	Bluesky
MI	House	James, John	R	33.9K	7,187	—
MI	House	McClain, Lisa	R	75.9K	28,920	—
MI	House	McDonald Rivet, Kristen	D	2,181	17,305	—
MI	House	Moolenaar, John	R	26K	3,528	—
MI	House	Scholten, Hillary	D	6,925	9,980	15,675
MI	House	Stevens, Haley	D	44.5K	no handle	—
MI	House	Thanedar, Shri	D	26.3K	6,256	9,642
MI	House	Tlaib, Rashida	D	554.5K	347,742	—
MI	House	Walberg, Tim	R	25.2K	3,797	—
MN	Senate	Klobuchar, Amy	D	97.2K	no handle	39,227
MN	Senate	Smith, Tina	D	127.2K	102,875	144,614
MN	House	Craig, Angie	D	38.1K	no handle	—
MN	House	Emmer, Tom	R	handle wrong	20,060	—
MN	House	Finstad, Brad	R	7,608	3,013	—
MN	House	Fischbach, Michelle	R	12.3K	10,206	—
MN	House	McCollum, Betty	D	42.8K	9,549	5,716
MN	House	Morrison, Kelly	D	5,055	handle wrong	—
MN	House	Omar, Ilhan	D	1.2M	no handle	—
MN	House	Stauber, Pete	R	21.6K	no handle	—
MO	Senate	Hawley, Joshua	R	100K	1,192,191	—
MO	Senate	Schmitt, Eric	R	72.3K	43,089	—
MO	House	Alford, Mark	R	17.6K	11,556	—
MO	House	Bell, Wesley	D	2,811	no handle	—
MO	House	Burlison, Eric	R	63.1K	8,808	—
MO	House	Cleaver, Emanuel	D	47.6K	9,247	8,171
MO	House	Graves, Sam	R	17.3K	8,912	—
MO	House	Onder, Robert	R	3,849	1,594	—
MO	House	Smith, Jason	R	78K	no handle	—
MO	House	Wagner, Ann	R	32.5K	3,984	—
MP	House	King-Hinds, Kimberlyn	R	904	2,627	—
MS	Senate	Hyde-Smith, Cindy	R	35.3K	23,460	—
MS	Senate	Wicker, Roger	R	134.4K	16,245	—
MS	House	Ezell, Mike	R	6,127	1,580	—
MS	House	Guest, Michael	R	17.6K	no handle	—
MS	House	Kelly, Trent	R	17.8K	4,151	—
MS	House	Thompson, Bennie	D	106.4K	20,685	—
MT	Senate	Daines, Steve	R	100.9K	22,739	—
MT	Senate	Sheehy, Tim	R	no handle	no handle	—
MT	House	Downing, Troy	R	3,193	1,621	—

State	Chamber	Member	Party	X	Instagram	Bluesky
MT	House	Zinke, Ryan	R	16.3K	12,759	—
NC	Senate	Budd, Ted	R	handle wrong	18,715	—
NC	Senate	Tillis, Thom	R	198K	25,205	—
NC	House	Adams, Alma	D	31.1K	13,186	12,402
NC	House	Davis, Donald	D	6,150	4,599	—
NC	House	Edwards, Charles (Chuck)	R	handle wrong	3,768	—
NC	House	Foushee, Valerie	D	6,263	5,545	11,258
NC	House	Foxx, Virginia	R	52.3K	10,550	—
NC	House	Harrigan, Pat	R	21.6K	6,758	—
NC	House	Harris, Mark	R	25.5K	2,177	—
NC	House	Hudson, Richard	R	32.5K	no handle	—
NC	House	Knott, Brad	R	5,152	2,458	—
NC	House	McDowell, Addison	R	6,305	1,186	—
NC	House	Moore, Tim	R	33.1K	10,005	—
NC	House	Murphy, Gregory	R	32K	3,300	—
NC	House	Ross, Deborah	D	13.9K	25,217	14,708
NC	House	Rouzer, David	R	21.3K	4,636	—
ND	Senate	Cramer, Kevin	R	53.4K	handle wrong	—
ND	Senate	Hoeven, John	R	120.6K	11,059	—
ND	House	Fedorchak, Julie	R	4,956	3,087	—
NE	Senate	Fischer, Deb	R	111.6K	7,064	—
NE	Senate	Ricketts, Pete	R	12.2K	4,220	—
NE	House	Bacon, Don	R	95.7K	8,770	—
NE	House	Flood, Mike	R	14.4K	no handle	—
NE	House	Smith, Adrian	R	21.6K	1,677	—
NH	Senate	Hassan, Margaret	D	148.6K	25,985	11,439
NH	Senate	Shaheen, Jeanne	D	130.4K	18,263	13,619
NH	House	Goodlander, Maggie	D	7,700	31,796	8,297
NH	House	Pappas, Chris	D	17.9K	no handle	—
NJ	Senate	Booker, Cory	D	225.8K	2,893,659	247,927
NJ	Senate	Kim, Andy	D	no handle	183,355	34,596
NJ	House	Conaway, Herbert	D	1,756	no handle	—
NJ	House	Gottheimer, Josh	D	35.1K	11,121	—
NJ	House	Kean, Thomas	R	9,993	3,918	—
NJ	House	McCluer, LaMonica	D	13.4K	31,368	—
NJ	House	Mejia, Analilia	D	no handle	no handle	—
NJ	House	Menendez, Robert	D	8,992	19,645	26,514
NJ	House	Norcross, Donald	D	13.9K	handle wrong	30,435
NJ	House	Pallone, Frank	D	60.5K	8,416	862

State	Chamber	Member	Party	X	Instagram	Bluesky
NJ	House	Pou, Nellie	D	1,101	17,059	—
NJ	House	Smith, Christopher	R	no handle	8,850	—
NJ	House	Van Drew, Jefferson	R	32.8K	11,209	—
NJ	House	Watson Coleman, Bonnie	D	47.4K	52,189	—
NM	Senate	Heinrich, Martin	D	13.1K	68,090	52,795
NM	Senate	Luján, Ben	D	49.1K	58,821	17,517
NM	House	Leger Fernandez, Teresa	D	24.5K	57,955	—
NM	House	Stansbury, Melanie	D	115.4K	no handle	—
NM	House	Vasquez, Gabriel (Gabe)	D	9,142	13,534	—
NV	Senate	Cortez Masto, Catherine	D	77.7K	30,786	4,954
NV	Senate	Rosen, Jacky	D	59.6K	handle wrong	8,695
NV	House	Amodei, Mark	R	18.8K	3,234	—
NV	House	Horsford, Steven	D	29.2K	48,114	—
NV	House	Lee, Susie	D	37.6K	8,189	7,770
NV	House	Titus, Dina	D	52.7K	10,629	4,363
NY	Senate	Gillibrand, Kirsten	D	36.4K	27,308	—
NY	Senate	Schumer, Charles	D	3.6M	464,359	103,943
NY	House	Clarke, Yvette	D	76K	handle wrong	—
NY	House	Espallat, Adriano	D	39.2K	handle wrong	—
NY	House	Garbarino, Andrew	R	14K	no handle	—
NY	House	Gillen, Laura	D	5,576	2,477	—
NY	House	Goldman, Dan	D	100.7K	116,570	—
NY	House	Jeffries, Hakeem	D	1M	828,264	—
NY	House	Kennedy, Timothy	D	13.4K	4,713	—
NY	House	LaLota, Nicolas	R	11.5K	4,705	—
NY	House	Langworthy, Nicholas	R	12.4K	3,925	—
NY	House	Latimer, George	D	2,158	3,751	—
NY	House	Lawler, Michael	R	39.2K	15,664	—
NY	House	Malliotakis, Nicole	R	handle wrong	no handle	—
NY	House	Mannion, John	D	3,764	3,750	—
NY	House	Meeks, Gregory	D	55.9K	10,444	20,244
NY	House	Meng, Grace	D	49K	no handle	10,577
NY	House	Morelle, Joseph	D	16.7K	no handle	2,295
NY	House	Nadler, Jerrold	D	407.6K	no handle	24,381
NY	House	Ocasio-Cortez, Alexandria	D	751.8K	no handle	294,591
NY	House	Riley, Josh	D	no handle	5,039	—
NY	House	Ryan, Patrick	D	13.1K	no handle	—
NY	House	Stefanik, Elise	R	640.6K	101,979	—
NY	House	Suozzi, Thomas	D	30.2K	no handle	—

State	Chamber	Member	Party	X	Instagram	Bluesky
NY	House	Tenney, Claudia	R	72.4K	no handle	—
NY	House	Tonko, Paul	D	27.7K	8,860	—
NY	House	Torres, Ritchie	D	50.7K	41,218	—
NY	House	Velázquez, Nydia	D	80.2K	no handle	9,053
OH	Senate	Husted, Jon	R	no handle	no handle	—
OH	Senate	Moreno, Bernie	R	149.5K	handle wrong	—
OH	House	Balderson, Troy	R	10K	no handle	—
OH	House	Beatty, Joyce	D	71.3K	73,170	—
OH	House	Brown, Shontel	D	49.3K	no handle	—
OH	House	Carey, Mike	R	6,656	no handle	—
OH	House	Davidson, Warren	R	88.5K	handle wrong	—
OH	House	Jordan, Jim	R	6.8M	no handle	—
OH	House	Joyce, David	R	28.8K	3,400	—
OH	House	Kaptur, Marcy	D	33.3K	9,444	—
OH	House	Landsman, Greg	D	21.7K	72,641	—
OH	House	Latta, Robert	R	39.4K	3,875	—
OH	House	Miller, Max	R	12.3K	5,557	—
OH	House	Rulli, Michael	R	no handle	no handle	—
OH	House	Sykes, Emilia	D	6,220	14,037	—
OH	House	Taylor, David	R	2,534	1,051	—
OH	House	Turner, Michael	R	56.8K	5,562	—
OK	Senate	Armstrong, Alan	R	no handle	no handle	—
OK	Senate	Lankford, James	R	168.2K	72,200	—
OK	House	Bice, Stephanie	R	30.7K	no handle	—
OK	House	Brecheen, Josh	R	20.1K	3,862	—
OK	House	Cole, Tom	R	42.1K	8,389	—
OK	House	Hern, Kevin	R	30.6K	no handle	—
OK	House	Lucas, Frank	R	27.1K	8,059	—
OR	Senate	Merkley, Jeff	D	448.4K	181,980	10,431
OR	Senate	Wyden, Ron	D	466.5K	75,465	210,312
OR	House	Bentz, Cliff	R	9,997	4,303	—
OR	House	Bonamici, Suzanne	D	35.3K	16,237	—
OR	House	Bynum, Janelle	D	2,931	15,870	11,091
OR	House	Dexter, Maxine	D	11.5K	49,655	—
OR	House	Hoyle, Valerie	D	7,527	4,604	—
OR	House	Salinas, Andrea	D	4,641	6,213	34,425
PA	Senate	Fetterman, John	D	no handle	101,767	112,397
PA	Senate	McCormick, Dave	R	no handle	23,621	—
PA	House	Boyle, Brendan	D	24.8K	no handle	—

State	Chamber	Member	Party	X	Instagram	Bluesky
PA	House	Bresnahan, Robert	R	2,957	2,332	—
PA	House	Dean, Madeleine	D	72.1K	89,086	—
PA	House	Deluzio, Chris	D	18.6K	27,390	13,792
PA	House	Evans, Dwight	D	21.2K	7,855	—
PA	House	Fitzpatrick, Brian	R	47.4K	16,630	—
PA	House	Houlahan, Chrissy	D	40.3K	50,555	23,560
PA	House	Joyce, John	R	20.7K	no handle	—
PA	House	Kelly, Mike	R	33.3K	no handle	—
PA	House	Lee, Summer	D	69.2K	156,714	—
PA	House	Mackenzie, Ryan	R	5,155	1,234	—
PA	House	Meuser, Daniel	R	34.2K	no handle	—
PA	House	Perry, Scott	R	158.7K	9,171	—
PA	House	Reschenthaler, Guy	R	38.1K	10,235	—
PA	House	Scanlon, Mary	D	57.4K	16,063	10,193
PA	House	Smucker, Lloyd	R	15.9K	no handle	—
PA	House	Thompson, Glenn	R	29.3K	8,930	—
PR	House	Hernández Rivera, Pablo José	D	3,551	28,910	—
RI	Senate	Reed, John	D	108.9K	no handle	19,292
RI	Senate	Whitehouse, Sheldon	D	569.5K	348,856	155,137
RI	House	Amo, Gabe	D	5,711	17,970	29,968
RI	House	Magaziner, Seth	D	17.8K	no handle	27,289
SC	Senate	Graham Nordone, Darline	R	no handle	no handle	—
SC	Senate	Scott, Tim	R	837K	212,428	—
SC	House	Biggs, Sheri	R	3,122	1,604	—
SC	House	Clyburn, James	D	167.6K	84,935	—
SC	House	Fry, Russell	R	21.6K	9,293	—
SC	House	Mace, Nancy	R	766.9K	310,572	—
SC	House	Norman, Ralph	R	63.6K	10,857	—
SC	House	Timmons, William	R	44.9K	9,096	—
SC	House	Wilson, Joe	R	208K	18,458	—
SD	Senate	Rounds, Mike	R	57K	8,224	—
SD	Senate	Thune, John	R	handle wrong	handle wrong	—
SD	House	Johnson, Dusty	R	33.3K	no handle	—
TN	Senate	Blackburn, Marsha	R	1.5M	156,186	—
TN	Senate	Hagerty, Bill	R	98.2K	24,072	—
TN	House	Burchett, Tim	R	211.9K	no handle	—
TN	House	Cohen, Steve	D	83.7K	16,588	—
TN	House	DesJarlais, Scott	R	26.1K	6,818	—
TN	House	Fleischmann, Charles	R	30.3K	no handle	—

State	Chamber	Member	Party	X	Instagram	Bluesky
TN	House	Harshbarger, Diana	R	27.2K	no handle	—
TN	House	Kustoff, David	R	23.6K	5,755	—
TN	House	Ogles, Andrew	R	125.6K	27,959	—
TN	House	Rose, John	R	38.5K	no handle	—
TN	House	Van Epps, Matt	R	no handle	no handle	—
TX	Senate	Cornyn, John	R	413.1K	no handle	—
TX	Senate	Cruz, Ted	R	4.1M	1,349,104	—
TX	House	Arrington, Jodey	R	27.2K	26,341	—
TX	House	Babin, Brian	R	42.6K	no handle	—
TX	House	Carter, John	R	22.5K	4,001	—
TX	House	Casar, Gregorio	D	85K	128,094	—
TX	House	Castro, Joaquin	D	253.9K	191,662	—
TX	House	Cloud, Michael	R	handle wrong	handle wrong	—
TX	House	Crenshaw, Dan	R	644.5K	2,202,559	—
TX	House	Crockett, Jasmine	D	278.8K	2,918,370	566,429
TX	House	Cuellar, Henry	D	33.2K	6,078	—
TX	House	De La Cruz, Mónica	R	8,875	5,538	—
TX	House	Doggett, Lloyd	D	50.8K	16,317	26,270
TX	House	Ellzey, Jake	R	5,658	no handle	—
TX	House	Escobar, Veronica	D	82.7K	30,258	—
TX	House	Fallon, Patrick	R	85.6K	10,723	—
TX	House	Fletcher, Lizzie	D	31.4K	17,945	—
TX	House	Garcia, Sylvia	D	63.4K	no handle	2,247
TX	House	Gill, Brandon	R	369.1K	956,520	—
TX	House	Goldman, Craig	R	2,351	1,364	—
TX	House	Gonzalez, Vicente	D	14.5K	handle wrong	—
TX	House	Gooden, Lance	R	no handle	no handle	—
TX	House	Green, Al	D	119.2K	139,048	136,835
TX	House	Hunt, Wesley	R	handle wrong	48,963	—
TX	House	Jackson, Ronny	R	40.5K	37,424	—
TX	House	Johnson, Julie	D	4,679	31,627	—
TX	House	Luttrell, Morgan	R	42.6K	139,157	—
TX	House	McCaul, Michael	R	66.3K	9,888	—
TX	House	Menefee, Christian	D	no handle	no handle	679
TX	House	Moran, Nathaniel	R	12.7K	4,842	—
TX	House	Nehls, Troy	R	238.8K	19,765	—
TX	House	Pfluger, August	R	29.3K	80,106	—
TX	House	Roy, Chip	R	306K	no handle	—
TX	House	Self, Keith	R	72.6K	26,430	—

State	Chamber	Member	Party	X	Instagram	Bluesky
TX	House	Sessions, Pete	R	39.8K	5,861	—
TX	House	Van Duyne, Beth	R	52.8K	43,560	—
TX	House	Veasey, Marc	D	34K	6,635	—
TX	House	Weber, Randy	R	35K	5,896	—
TX	House	Williams, Roger	R	24.9K	no handle	—
UT	Senate	Curtis, John	R	handle wrong	handle wrong	—
UT	Senate	Lee, Mike	R	852.7K	49,871	—
UT	House	Kennedy, Mike	R	2,712	1,838	—
UT	House	Maloy, Celeste	R	3,327	2,322	—
UT	House	Moore, Blake	R	16.4K	6,237	—
UT	House	Owens, Clarence	R	43.3K	16,875	—
VA	Senate	Kaine, Timothy	D	no handle	64,809	84,645
VA	Senate	Warner, Mark	D	472.5K	104,418	—
VA	House	Beyer, Donald	D	123.7K	45,641	83,815
VA	House	Cline, Ben	R	53.6K	9,779	—
VA	House	Griffith, H.	R	37.6K	3,431	—
VA	House	Kiggans, Jennifer	R	12.9K	6,971	—
VA	House	McClellan, Jennifer	D	7,781	24,319	15,929
VA	House	McGuire, John	R	4,437	1,600	—
VA	House	Scott, Robert	D	42.4K	8,402	—
VA	House	Subramanyam, Suhas	D	9,986	42,989	—
VA	House	Vindman, Eugene	D	12.5K	18,021	—
VA	House	Walkinshaw, James	D	no handle	no handle	—
VA	House	Wittman, Robert	R	34.8K	6,835	—
VI	House	Plaskett, Stacey	D	216.3K	76,192	—
VT	Senate	Sanders, Bernard	I	11.5M	no handle	572,693
VT	Senate	Welch, Peter	D	handle wrong	handle wrong	3,716
VT	House	Balint, Becca	D	32.2K	429,808	65,455
WA	Senate	Cantwell, Maria	D	230K	no handle	28,914
WA	Senate	Murray, Patty	D	469K	180,456	84,428
WA	House	Baumgartner, Michael	R	11.9K	1,845	—
WA	House	DelBene, Suzan	D	34.3K	14,603	—
WA	House	Gluesenkamp Perez, Marie	D	24.9K	20,582	22,778
WA	House	Jayapal, Pramila	D	563.4K	699,608	75,909
WA	House	Larsen, Rick	D	22.4K	6,218	—
WA	House	Newhouse, Dan	R	26.6K	8,011	—
WA	House	Randall, Emily	D	no handle	no handle	—
WA	House	Schrier, Kim	D	18.9K	no handle	—
WA	House	Smith, Adam	D	46.9K	16,305	31,292

State	Chamber	Member	Party	X	Instagram	Bluesky
WA	House	Strickland, Marilyn	D	9,128	11,615	135
WI	Senate	Baldwin, Tammy	D	148K	50,751	32,434
WI	Senate	Johnson, Ron	R	709.1K	92,667	—
WI	House	Fitzgerald, Scott	R	15.3K	no handle	—
WI	House	Grothman, Glenn	R	18.6K	5,755	—
WI	House	Moore, Gwen	D	44.4K	22,666	—
WI	House	Pocan, Mark	D	113.4K	21,060	51,189
WI	House	Steil, Bryan	R	34.9K	no handle	—
WI	House	Tiffany, Thomas	R	43.9K	no handle	—
WI	House	Van Orden, Derrick	R	11.3K	6,874	—
WI	House	Wied, Tony	R	5,884	961	—
WV	Senate	Capito, Shelley	R	102.1K	15,965	—
WV	Senate	Justice, Jim	R	no handle	14,149	—
WV	House	Miller, Carol	R	19K	no handle	—
WV	House	Moore, Riley	R	95.8K	5,559	—
WY	Senate	Barrasso, John	R	179.4K	no handle	—
WY	Senate	Lummis, Cynthia	R	401.1K	9,147	—
WY	House	Hageman, Harriet	R	99.8K	no handle	—

04 What this brief cannot tell you

It cannot rank Congress by followers. No platform here supports that sentence. Bluesky is missing a party, Instagram is missing about a quarter of the members, and the largest counts on X arrive as 11.5M.

It cannot tell you these are constituents, or voters, or even people. A follower is an account that clicked a button, possibly years ago, possibly from another country, possibly automated. Nothing here separates an engaged voter in the member's district from a dormant account in another hemisphere.

It cannot tell you anyone is reading. A follower count measures an audience that accumulated, not one that showed up. Attention paid on a particular day is a different quantity, and it needs a different file.

It is one day. 2026-08-15, frozen on purpose. Every count has moved since, and a fresh collection would be a new measurement rather than a check on this one.

It cannot tell you why the party gap exists. The brief establishes that Bluesky's congressional population is one party. Whether that is about when the platform grew, who left X and when, or a staffing decision repeated office by office, is not in this file.

05 What you should have learned

- Follower counts are distributed far more unequally than congressional power is: the ten largest accounts hold 43.3% of all Instagram followers in this file, and the bottom half of the members hold 3.6%.
- Office tracks the audience loosely and not finely: the median senator counted here has 50,751 followers against 10,550 for the median representative, but the largest account of all belongs to a member of the House, and neither the Speaker nor the Senate majority leader has a usable row in the file.
- Coverage is a finding, not a nuisance. No platform describes the whole institution, and the best of them reaches 91.2% of the 537 members.
- One platform is missing a party: 0 of 274 Republicans are on Bluesky under their own chamber's domain, against 51.5% of Democrats. Any average taken there is an average of one side.
- A list of handles kept by hand goes wrong fastest about the people whose jobs change, which is why 11 of the 34 wrong handles belong to members who were promoted.

06 Extensions

- `all_members.csv` gives an exact `instagram` count for most members alongside `chamber`. Sort by the count, then compare the House rows against the Senate rows. Does the more powerful chamber have the larger audiences all the way down, or only in the middle?
- `all_members.csv` also carries `state` and `party`. Group the counts by party and take a median for each. Is the gap between the parties larger or smaller than the gap between the chambers?
- `coverage.csv` gives `pct_covered` for each platform, with the reasons for the misses broken out in `no_handle`, `no_account` and `other_miss`. Which platform gives the most complete picture of Congress, and which kind of miss does each one suffer from?
- `party_coverage.csv` splits coverage by party in the `pct` column. Find the platform where one party is barely present, then ask what you would have concluded from its median without checking.
- `platform_leaders.csv` names the most-followed member on each platform in `member`, with `covered` beside it. They differ. What is a follower count actually measuring?
- **Stretch.** Bluesky's public interface is free and needs no key. Re-collect the Bluesky column today and set it against `bluesky` in `all_members.csv`. How much does a year move a follower count, and does it move every member the same way?
- **Stretch.** Roll-call records say how often a member votes with their party, and committee rosters say who chairs what. Join either to `all_members.csv` and ask whether a large audience predicts anything at all about how a member behaves inside the building.

07 Sources

Data

Follower counts. Read from public profile pages on 2026-08-15, signed out, one profile at a time. That reading is frozen at that date and never re-fetched, so every table above can be rebuilt with no network at all.

- X — `https://x.com/<handle>`. Rounded counts only. The API that would give exact counts is priced from \$200 a month: `https://developer.x.com/en/products/x-api`
- Instagram — `https://www.instagram.com/<handle>/`. A rounded count on the screen, a fuller one carried in the page.
- Bluesky — the free public interface at `https://public.api.bsky.app/xrpc/app.bsky.actor.getProfiles`. No key, no account. Exact counts.

Who is in Congress, and their handles. `unitedstates/congress-legislators`, current members and the social-media crosswalk, retrieved 2026-08-15: `https://unitedstates.github.io/congress-legislators/legislators-current.csv` and the `legislators-social-media.json` beside it. Both are kept exactly as they arrived.

The data itself

Every figure above is drawn from these tables. They are plain CSV, they open in a spreadsheet, and they are yours to take further.

`all_members.csv`, `coverage.csv`, `party_coverage.csv`, `platform_leaders.csv`, `stale_handles.csv`

Check	Result
every member was looked for on every platform	TRUE
no platform covers the whole chamber	TRUE
coverage differs between platforms rather than being one wall	TRUE
the Bluesky gap is a party gap, not a size gap	TRUE
X covers both parties at rates within 25 points of each other	TRUE
a wrong handle is a different failure from a missing one	TRUE
stale handles concentrate among members whose job changed	TRUE
the exact number harvested is the follower count and not another field	TRUE
the full member table agrees with the coverage table, platform by platform	TRUE
the platforms do not agree on one answer	TRUE

WHY THIS DATA CANNOT BE FETCHED AGAIN

The dataset behind this page comes from a source you cannot fetch today, and no assistant can fetch it for you.

WHY NOT. The numbers are follower counts — X, Instagram and Bluesky — for all 537 sitting members of Congress, read once on 15 August 2026.

There is no file to download: no platform publishes a list of congressional follower counts. X sells the API that would answer the question for \$200 a month, and its old free endpoint now returns an empty page. So the numbers were taken the way a person gets them: a logged-out browser loaded each public profile, about 900 page loads over half an hour, and wrote down the number on the screen. Follower counts move by the minute. The snapshot cannot be reproduced, only re-taken, and a re-take is a different measurement of a different day.

WHAT EXISTS INSTEAD. One of the three platforms is genuinely open:

Bluesky has a free public API with no key and no account (public.api.bsky.app), and an assistant can query it for you today. The handles must come from somewhere else – a volunteer-maintained roster called unitedstates/congress-legislators covers X and Instagram, and congressional Bluesky handles can be guessed against senate.gov and house.gov, domains only the chambers control, so a hit cannot be the wrong person. A fresh collection built that way is not a check on this one; it is a new, equally valid snapshot of a moving number.

WHAT YOU CAN STILL CHECK. These numbers say whether you are holding the same snapshot this book describes:

- 537 members, asked about on three platforms: 1,611 rows, misses included
- X yielded a count for 490 members, Instagram for 388, Bluesky for 135
- of the 135 on Bluesky, 134 are Democrats and none are Republicans